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Prof. Liz

Design Thinking

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How to Enhance Freedom of Expression at Dartmouth?

This project was really meaningful to me, because I got to choose whom to be with as teammates. The topic was very relevant to me especially (1) I have been an activist for change my whole life, in particular relating to humanitarian law (2) recently I felt like my voice was narrowed due to recent changes in the U.S. administration. Whenever I was working on this project, I kept thinking about whether we were really considering all those aspects ‘Do people want to be associated with their political opinions?’

During the interviews, it was mentioned a lot how there’s a division between left and right wing of people (Democrat or Republican), about U.S. policy in the Middle East, and about student protests around American campuses. Similarly, at a liberal school like Dartmouth, students who are ‘right wing’ feel isolated, and international students are feared to be involved with politics given this political climate. These interviews we conducted with various kinds of students, faculty members, and several administrators really helped us shape our final project. At first, it was challenging to come to a person and ask about what they thought of freedom of expression at Dartmouth all of a sudden. But I think this was the most rewarding part of the experience, as I pushed myself to talk to people of various positions. This showed me that indeed doing interviews like in anthropology helps us hugely along the way for a final product.

I learned that my skills really grew at Figma. I had been learning it since winter term at DaliLab, and when my team decided to design a website, I wanted to take that task. I learned that I really enjoyed working with UI design, and it made me think about taking a class on it! I learned that the design process is constantly reevaluating user interviews, getting ideas out there on the board, and testing the design as quickly as possible. In the future, I would like to keep applying concepts like lateral thinking and user journeys into all kinds of design.

I would give 33.3% to everyone in the team, and I had fun working with them. Sienna created a board design on Photoshop and worked heavily on the fourth upload of the whiteboard; Caleb printed user interview pictures and did those interviews with me; and I did the website design on Figma, helped with whiteboards. Everyone equally contributed to the slides as well.